Prisms of the Past: Preserving the Legacy of Ashurbanipal through Photography

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Background:

Cuneiform:

- What: One of the oldest writing systems, used for many different ancient languages of the Middle East, such as Akkadian, Sumerian, and Hittite



- When: 3000-0 BCE (Neo-Assyrian: 911-609 BCE)
- How: Imprinted by indenting styli onto wet clay surfaces resulting in a 3D effect

Ashurbanipal:

- Who: The last great ruler of the Neo-Assyrian empire who was also deeply knowledgeable in writing
- When: 669-631 BCE
- What: Along with conquering, he sent his soldiers all over the empire collecting tablets for the library of Nineveh
- Why: Sought to assemble all written knowledge and its contents



Prisms:



The Chicago Prism

- What are they: Polygonal objects designed to bear royal inscriptions
- Why this shape: They have a large surface area to volume ratio to fit more text, and the shape is easier to inscribe than a round surface

Ashurbanipal's texts (annals):

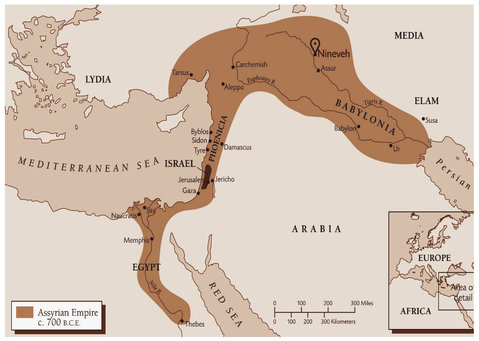
- Language: Majority are in the Standard Babylonian dialect
- Content: Describe Ashurbanipal's battle victories, building campaigns, religious dedications, and scholarly achievements
- Creation: See results section!



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From Nineveh to Chicago:

- What: The capital of the Assyrian Empire
- When: 705-612 BCE
- Where:



- Found: Prisms were illegally excavated from the foundations of the temples and palaces in the mid-1800s to early 1900s then put on the market
- Bought: Purchased by Daniel Luckenbill for Breasted from Georges Khayat in Baghdad in 1919-1920
- Moved: Brought back to Chicago as part of Luckenbill's "baggage" in "a photographic trunk." The Chicago Prism (see left) was hand-carried throughout his journey back to Chicago

Our Work:

Goal: Accurately represent the color, texture, shape, and inscriptions of the prisms through photography, and in so doing, discover clues into the processes by which they were created

Photography Methods:

- Foam: Placed underneath objects in order to level them for a more even focus
- Lighting: From the upper-left in order to maximize the readability of the wedges, secondary light to minimize glossiness and reveal shape obscured by shadow
- Challenges: The wider camera lens needed to fit the large fragments in frame was suboptimal for capturing detail, thus we used a raised tripod set up to reduce the amount of fragments for which this lens was needed

Results:



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1. A thick layer of tempered clay is used to form the shape of the prism while cleaner clay is **layered** externally for inscription
2. **Plant tempered clay** assists drying by preventing cracks (the plant matter retains moisture longer) but leaves voids behind
3. **Perforations** allow mounting the prism on a spindle which assists in writing, firing, and installation

Rulings were made to divide campaigns or sections within a campaign from the next. These were made with either:

4. Strings
5. Styli



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Prisms are hollow–they have have a thick flat base from which the body of the prism is either formed…

6. By **coiling** clay into cylinder shape, resulting in heavy ribbing

7. On a **wheel**, resulting in visible rilling grooves

Sources and Acknowledgments:

Taylor, Jon. "Some Practicalities and Aethestics of Mesopotamian Foundation Prisms and Cylinders." *Keilschriftartefakte Untersuchungen Zur Materialität von Keilschriftdokumenten*, PeWe-Verlag, 2018, pp. 33–62.

Photos:

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